

GAUNTLET - Reference Guide

Version 0.6.1 - First Playtest Revision

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Setup

1. Shuffle the Playable Deck to form the Draw Pile.
2. Secretly arrange three Territories.
3. Join both Territory lines and reveal all six.
4. Prepare the Leader and supplemental components.
5. Place the Player Token immediately before that player's end of the Gauntlet.
6. Draw three cards to form the opening Hand.
7. Roll to determine the first player; reroll ties.
8. Keep Draw Pile, Discard Pile, Graveyard, Hand, Asset Bank, Reserve, Gambit, Tactic, Leader, and faction components visibly separate.

Turn

1. **Capture:** Capture a Territory occupied but not controlled.
2. **Draw:** Draw one card.
3. **Action Opportunity before movement:** Use the turn's normal Action Opportunity, if desired.
4. **Movement:** Advance, hold, or withdraw. Resolve any battle immediately. A battle ends the movement that started it and unused movement is lost.
5. **Action Opportunity after movement:** Use the normal Action Opportunity here only if it was not used before movement.
6. **Cleanup:** Resolve end-of-turn effects and discard down to three cards in Hand.

A player moves after a battle only when an Order, card, or rule explicitly permits it.

Battle

1. **Opening effects:** Establish attacker, defender, and contested position. Resolve effects such as Terms before Gambits are set.
2. **Set Gambits:** Attacker sets up to one eligible Gambit face down or passes; defender then does the same.
3. **Form Reserves:** Set Hands physically aside. Each player draws three temporary cards to form a Reserve.
4. **Reveal Gambits:** Reveal simultaneously. Resolve priority effects, then other shared-timing effects.
5. **Choose Tactics:** Attacker chooses up to one eligible Tactic from Reserve face down or passes; defender then does the same.
6. **Reveal Tactics:** Reveal simultaneously and resolve their effects.
7. **Resolve battle:** Resolve before-dice effects, roll, apply advantage/disadvantage, rerolls, and modifiers, then determine the winner.
8. **Aftermath:** Resolve retreat, occupation, other result effects, card destinations, destination triggers, and follow-up movement.

Card eligibility

- **Gambit:** card with a Gambit or Battle effect.
- **Tactic:** card with a Tactic or Battle effect.
- A Gambit or Tactic does not resolve merely because it was placed or revealed early.
- A replacement takes the same role and does not reopen an earlier timing window.
- Additional Tactics played after normal reveal are face up and resolve only effects whose timing remains available.

Shared timing

When both players control effects at the same timing, the attacker resolves one controlled effect, then the defender resolves one, alternating until none remain. Each player chooses the order of effects they control.

Battle totals

- Each net advantage adds one die; use the highest result.
- Each net disadvantage adds one die; use the lowest result.
- Advantage and disadvantage cancel one-for-one.
- Apply rerolls and changes to the die result, then numerical modifiers.
- Higher total wins.
- On a tie, the defender wins if they control the contested Territory or are defending a Last Stand. Otherwise reroll.

Aftermath order

1. Determine the battle result.
2. Apply effects that replace losing with withdrawal.
3. Resolve immediate result triggers, including normal Command gain.
4. Resolve normal retreat and occupation.
5. Resolve additional retreats and final-position effects.
6. Resolve other Aftermath effects that occur before battle cards leave.
7. Move battle cards to their destinations.
8. Resolve effects triggered by those destinations.
9. Resolve end-of-Aftermath effects and follow-up movement.

Normal destinations

- **Gambits** → **Graveyard**
- **Tactics** → **Discard Pile**
- **Remaining Reserve** → **Discard Pile**

Card-specific text overrides the normal destination.

Withdrawal and retreat

Effect-caused withdrawal

- Ends the battle immediately unless stated otherwise.
- No winner or loser; win, loss, and retreat triggers do not occur.
- Do not resolve remaining Battle effects or roll dice.
- Attacking player returns to the position from which they entered.
- Defending player moves one position toward their own end; attacker occupies the contested position.
- If both withdraw, move attacker first, then defender.
- Use normal battle-card cleanup unless stated otherwise.
- Withdrawal caused during opening effects before a pending battle uses the same movement, but no battle or Aftermath occurs.

Retreat after a loss

- Losing attacker returns to the position from which they entered.
- Losing defender retreats one position toward their own end.
- Winning attacker occupies the contested position.
- Winning defender remains there.
- Additional retreats resolve one position at a time.
- A player cannot retreat through the opponent.

Running the Gauntlet

1. Win a battle on the opponent's final Territory.
2. The opponent retreats beyond the Gauntlet; occupy the final Territory.
3. Capture it at the start of the next turn if still occupying it.
4. Later advance beyond the Gauntlet, beginning a Last Stand battle.
5. During the Last Stand, the defender has Defender's Advantage and adds +1 to their battle total.
6. If the attacker wins, they have run the Gauntlet and win the game.
7. If the defender wins, the attacker retreats normally and the game continues.

Assets and Overlays

- Asset limit equals the number of Territories controlled.
- When banking at the limit, a player may discard one controlled Asset to make room during the same Action Opportunity unless an effect prevents it from leaving play.
- An Overlay is controlled by the controller of its Territory.
- Overlay control changes with the Territory; ownership does not.
- A removed Overlay normally goes to its owner's Discard Pile.

Factions

Faction	Resource / progression	Victory	Leaders
Military	Command, maximum 2	Run the Gauntlet.	General, Commandant
Diplomats	Influence, 0–10; Treaty Articles	Run the Gauntlet or complete the Peace Treaty.	Ambassador, Senator
Financiers	Capital, Treasury, and Deeds	Run the Gauntlet or achieve Controlling Interest.	Banker, Executive
Intelligence	Intel, Missions, and Operation Progress	Run the Gauntlet or complete a Special Operation.	Ranger, Spymaster
Mystics	Three Rites, Invocation, Transmutation, and Ritual of Ascendance	Run the Gauntlet or complete the Ritual of Ascendance.	Alchemist, Spirit Walker
Inquisition	Conviction, maximum 4; Purge and doctrine	Run the Gauntlet or achieve Purification.	Grand Inquisitor, Witch Hunter

Card pool

Pool	Cards	Total value	Unique cards
Neutral	50	119	Manifest Destiny
Military	12	35	Shock and Awe
Diplomats	12	35	None
Financiers	12	36	Corner the Market
Intelligence	12	36	Sleeper Network
Mystics	12	36	Necromancy
Inquisition	12	37	None

Territory pool

- **Quicksand:** Beginning movement here prevents voluntary withdrawal and limits movement to one position that turn.
- **Poisonous Gas:** A player may have only one Gambit or Tactic in the battle. Tactics go to the Graveyard; choosing no Tactic costs one initial Reserve card, if able.
- **Difficult Terrain:** Entering ends movement. Beginning or entering there prevents an after-movement Action card that turn.
- **Garrison:** Its defending controller draws one additional initial Reserve card.
- **Disrupted Supply Lines:** Its occupant may have only one active banked Asset.
- **Ruined Storehouse:** Its occupant may draw the top Discard Pile card instead of the normal Draw Pile card.
- **Field Hospital:** Its controller may send one qualifying battle card to the Discard Pile instead of the Graveyard.
- **Exposed Flank:** During its controller's counterattack, the occupier cannot set a Gambit.
- **High Ground:** The defender gains advantage.
- **Fortified Pass:** When its controller defends, the attacker's banked Assets are inactive.
- **Insurgency:** An opposing occupier's banked Assets are inactive until they gain control or leave.
- **Watchtower:** When its controller defends, the attacker sets a Gambit face up or passes before the defender sets normally.
- **Supply Depot:** Its occupying controller draws one additional card during the Draw step.
- **Old Battlefield:** Its controller may put one unchosen Reserve card in the Graveyard instead of the Discard Pile.
- **Refuge:** A player who voluntarily withdraws onto it draws one card.
- **Command Tent:** Its occupying controller may play an Action card both before and after movement that turn.
- **Monastery:** While its controller occupies it, cards cannot leave Graveyards; Arcane cards have no effect in battles there.
- **Training Grounds:** Its defending controller may discard and replace their entire initial Reserve before choosing Tactics.
- **King's Road:** Beginning the turn there grants one additional movement position.
- **Toll Bridge:** Voluntarily advancing from it requires discarding one Hand card.
- **Smuggler's Pass:** Its occupying controller may stash one Hand card and later play it for its Action or set it as a Gambit.
- **Arena: Spoils of War:** No Defender's Advantage; reroll ties. Winner may return one unchosen Reserve card to Hand.
- **Arena: No Quarter:** No Defender's Advantage; reroll ties. Loser retreats one additional position.
- **Arena: Single Combat:** No Defender's Advantage; reroll ties. All banked Assets are inactive.
- **Arena: Grand Melee:** No Defender's Advantage; reroll ties. Each player draws one additional initial Reserve card and may choose one additional Tactic.

Refer to the governing rulebook, faction guides, Neutral Card Pool, and Territory Pool for complete rules and exact text.